

Congress and, therefore, the family duo of Sonia Gandhi and Rahul is that their focus is on a compassionate and extensive spending programme targeting the economically weaker sections. Whether it is President Pratibha Patil's address to the joint session of Parliament or a chamber of commerce discussion with Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee on the competition policy, it is the common man who is cited as the chief beneficiary. Even a blatant reformist move such as PSU disinvestment is sugar-coated as a move to increase social sector expenditure.

Yet, despite the hype—and the intent—there seems to be a disconnect between promise and delivery. All the UPA's flagship schemes have run into rough weather. The National Rural Employment Generation Act (NREGA) is leaking through the loopholes as it lacks an effective mechanism to ensure the wages reach the worker; the much celebrated Forest Rights Act meant to give tribals land titles has not reached most of its target group. Sonia Gandhi is pushing for the National Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act and the

Women's Reservation Bill, but both are caught in political wrangling; the Food Security Act is still to be drafted, while the prime minister's dream to create a slum-free India in five years may have earned the poverty alleviation minister many moments before the camera, but the plan has only reached the concept paper stage.

The stellar stars of the Cabinet have all been given economic and security portfolios, leaving the social sector portfolios to balance the gender and caste equation of the Cabinet. There is a Dalit to head the Ministry of Social Empowerment, two others for Urban Poverty Alleviation and Labour, a tribal for the Ministry of Tribal Affairs, a woman (and a Scheduled Caste) for women and child development and an Assamese for the North-east. This is tokenism at its best. Moreover, the personality of a minister goes a long way in building the profile of the ministry. Look at the difference between a Shivraj Patil and a



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A low profile academic-turned-party worker, Joshi dresses simply in white *kurtas* and a Titan watch. A stickler for details, he is a good administrator to oversee the UPA's flagship schemes. He is also the Rajasthan PCC chief and divides his time between state politics and Krishi Bhawan.

***THE FUNDS** Rural Development: Rs 56,883 crore in 2008-09 (revised) to Rs 62,707 crore in 2009-10. Panchayati Raj: Rs 4,000 crore (including state plans) in 2008-09 to Rs 4,781 crore this year.

THE AGENDA Wants to bring in biometrics to ensure that wages reach the rural worker and yet keep the system transparent. Thinks that Panchayat should become the third tier of governance and that schemes like the NREGA will help him empower local bodies. But Mani Shankar Aiyar has said all this much before him. Moreover, the NREGA story has many loopholes. Joshi blames this on the implementation at the state level.

THE REPORT CARD Thanks to Rahul Gandhi, the NREGA is more successful as a marketing story than a welfare scheme. Joshi needs to tour states beyond Rajasthan to ensure its effective implementation and the Panchayati Raj Ministry needs more of Joshi's attention. Sonia Gandhi's favourite Relief and Rehabilitation Bill still hangs in limbo due to coalition pressures.

* All figures are plan plus non-plan expenditure